

SK2222 V23 Varieties of Democracy and Democratization

The course was held for the 10th time since 2015, in Spring 2024. Course responsible was Professor Staffan I. Lindberg. Others teaching in 2024 were Dr. Fabio Angiolillo and Assist. Professor Valeriya Mechkova. Maria Lilleste was course administrator.

The course content was a little further adjusted this year to reflect the growing trend of autocratization in the world and the accompanying state of the art in the scientific literature. The graded assignments were changed to one multiple choice exam (new) to stimulate and evaluate reading of the course literature early in the course period; one group-presentation in seminar form (new); and one short paper on a topic among a list of predefined ones (new list); alongside the final course paper. Unfortunately, the grades division in Ladok were not changed accordingly which caused some confusion among the students. In addition, we as the teaching team were a little late with providing written instructions for the new assignments, which caused some further frustrations. It also became clear that a significant number of students this year did not have previous experiences with writing final course papers that includes empirical analyses, and we found that the quality of the written final course papers have been going down over the last few years. Finally, we have been following the structure of providing instructions for various parts of the course, assignments, readings, and so on in different parts of the online system. The students really did not like that.

For the coming year (Spring 2025), we have decided to make the following reforms:

- Course responsibility will be shared between Staffan I Lindberg and Fabio Angiolillo.
- Collect all information to students in one full document (extending the course guide to become a traditional, full-blown syllabus), including all detailed instructions for all graded assignments.
- Conduct a joint review of the content of all lectures together to enhance the coherence and structure of the material communicated to the students.
- Connect the group presentation assignment with the following short paper assignment in a clear way.
- Revise the lecture schedule to include one lecture and discussion session on “how to write a final paper”.
- Revise the instructions and expectations for the final course paper to exclude empirical analysis and focus on theory/literature, study design, data, and methods.
- Standardize the amount of time students get with their respective final paper-advisor so all students get the same amount of feedback and advising.

Completion Rate

21 students registered this year compared to 24 in 2023 (inclusive of 2 re-registered) out of which 14 (67%) completed the course by the time of writing (was same 67% in 2022 and 2023). 0 failed (U), 9 passed (G), and 5 received a high pass (VG). For 2023 it was 0 U, 12 G, and 4 VG.

Student Evaluations

10 out of 21 students (48% - the attached says 24 respondents but we only had 21 registered) answered the course evaluation so the results must be taken with a grain of salt, or at least interpreted with care and keeping in mind that most students did not provide their views.

Having said that, on several questions 6 to 7 out of 10 rated the course as Very or rather good, and the rest “neither”. More critical responses with 4-5 respondents answering “rather bad/very bad” pertained to seminars, organization, and instructions in particular.

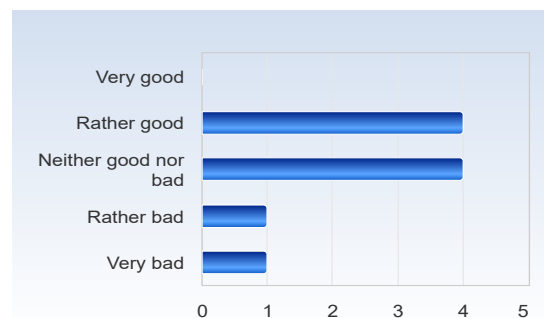


SK2222 V24 Varieties of Democracy and Democratization

Respondents: 24
Answer Count: 10
Answer Frequency: 41,67 %

Overall, how would you assess the course?

Overall, how would you assess the course?	Number of responses
Very good	0 (0,0%)
Rather good	4 (40,0%)
Neither good nor bad	4 (40,0%)
Rather bad	1 (10,0%)
Very bad	1 (10,0%)
Total	10 (100,0%)



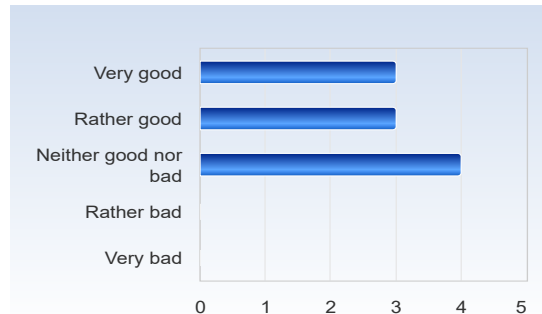
	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the course?	3,1	1,0	32,1 %	1,0	3,0	3,0	4,0	4,0

Comment

The themes in the course are very interesting but there has been no incentive to learn. There have been no opportunities to engage with the literature. Instead we have been left alone with heaps of text and no real explanation to what it means in a bigger context. I would have appreciated more seminars for discussion and more short papers to be able to assess what I have learned and what I need to improve on. It's an interesting course but it's ruined by poor structure and lack of information.

Overall, how would you assess the lectures?

Overall, how would you assess the lectures?	Number of responses
Very good	3 (30,0%)
Rather good	3 (30,0%)
Neither good nor bad	4 (40,0%)
Rather bad	0 (0,0%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)
Total	10 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the lectures?	3,9	0,9	22,5 %	3,0	3,0	4,0	4,5	5,0

Comment

Too many tables and graphs without context...

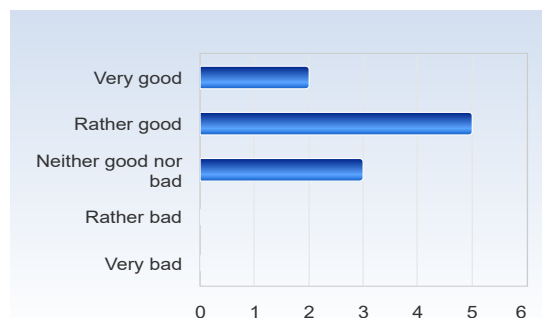
The lectures we're the extremely motivating to link everything that we learned during the master.

Some lectures were rather repetitive especially in the first part of the course. However I found the concepts did relate to one another and built upon each other nicely. I also think that not addressing current events during the course was a missed opportunity for real world applications of the concepts and tone-deaf.

Sometimes lectures were more focused on describing graphs and methodologies rather than actually providing the basis for a discussion on the selected topics.

Overall, how would you assess the teachers?

Overall, how would you assess the teachers?	Number of responses
Very good	2 (20,0%)
Rather good	5 (50,0%)
Neither good nor bad	3 (30,0%)
Rather bad	0 (0,0%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)
Total	10 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the teachers?	3,9	0,7	18,9 %	3,0	3,5	4,0	4,0	5,0



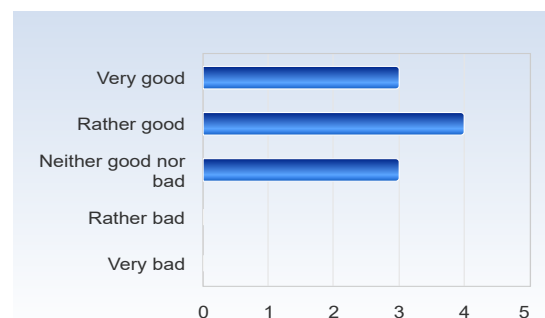
Comment

I found one lecturer to be dismissive and condescending especially towards female-identifying students when they would ask questions or otherwise contribute in class. I also heard from female-identifying students that this particular lecturer was rude and unhelpful during their individual supervisory sessions, to the point where they said they wanted to cry. The other lecturers I found insightful, kind, and knowledgeable in their field

All the teachers were great at teaching their lectures and seminars. It was especially enjoyable to have guest lectures and play the card game with Fabio (it was a fun alternative way of learning). Fabio and Valeriya were approachable, friendly and always helpful. In contrast, Staffan was disparaging.

Overall, how would you assess the literature?

Overall, how would you assess the literature?	Number of responses
Very good	3 (30,0%)
Rather good	4 (40,0%)
Neither good nor bad	3 (30,0%)
Rather bad	0 (0,0%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)
Total	10 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the literature?	4,0	0,8	20,4 %	3,0	3,5	4,0	4,5	5,0

Comment

Would have appreciated more opportunities to discuss the literature in seminars.

I really enjoyed most of the literature. Good topics, good research and interesting methods. However, I would have liked a broader selection of literature. While V-Dem publish good research, it could strengthen my understanding to read more about other approaches to democracy and its element. However, it's my responsibility too since I always have the chance to look for research on my own.

A lot of papers but little time to read them carefully.

We had to read too much for the multiple-choice exam. The stress of it all made it hard to really dig into the readings, question them, or engage deeply with them. Because of the time concern, I ended up just skimming the abstract, introduction, and conclusion of each piece. It's a shame because some of the readings were rather interesting



Overall, how would you assess the seminars?

Overall, how would you assess the seminars?	Number of responses
Very good	0 (0,0%)
Rather good	4 (40,0%)
Neither good nor bad	2 (20,0%)
Rather bad	4 (40,0%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)
Total	10 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the seminars?	3,0	0,9	31,4 %	2,0	2,0	3,0	4,0	4,0

Comment

More student-led discussions with teacher guidance. It felt like we had to guess what we needed to bring up in the presentations.

Good, nothing to complain about except the seminar on the short papers. The structure we had on that seminar was more useless than necessary. A better idea would be to provide the short papers to everyone and give every student the assignment to evaluate another student's paper?

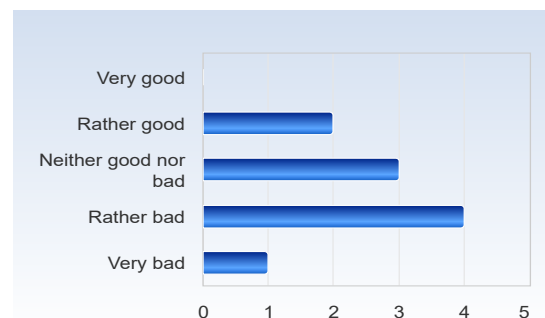
The seminars seemed poorly planned. I didn't mind the exam -- in my country they are quite common even at the master's level -- but the lack of communications and expectations around the exam were completely unacceptable. The seminar about our short paper was also not planned; after failing to send our peers' papers we were forced to make a group presentation in the seminar period and present which was honestly a waste of time and did not contribute to learning outcomes.

The seminars needed more planning. After the short paper, we had a seminar for which we received no instructions. The teacher told us to prepare a small group presentation for the topics during the lecture (even though the members might have analyzed different aspects of the selected topic in their paper) and after that 5-10 minutes were reserved to questions. Clearly, without former instructions, the discussion navigated the surface of the literature without really tackling key theoretical and empirical problems. Not so good for critical thinking.

In one of the seminars, we were unexpectedly asked to give a group presentation to the rest of the seminar group. We only found out about this requirement when the seminar began, which was quite surprising. The lack of prior notification about the presentation was unconventional. While the seminar itself was fine, it was inefficient to use seminar time for presentation preparation, something we could have easily done beforehand.

Overall, how would you assess the course paper tutorials?

Overall, how would you assess the course paper tutorials?	Number of responses
Very good	0 (0,0%)
Rather good	2 (20,0%)
Neither good nor bad	3 (30,0%)
Rather bad	4 (40,0%)
Very bad	1 (10,0%)
Total	10 (100,0%)





	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the course paper tutorials?	2,6	1,0	37,2 %	1,0	2,0	2,5	3,0	4,0

Comment

The tutorials themselves were good but only having two tutorials for the amount of work that is expected just leads to the course paper being based on guesses.

The tutorials were good, but there should have been more time between them. As it was this year, we only had 3-4 working days between the tutorials. The second tutorial could have taken place at least one week later than it did.

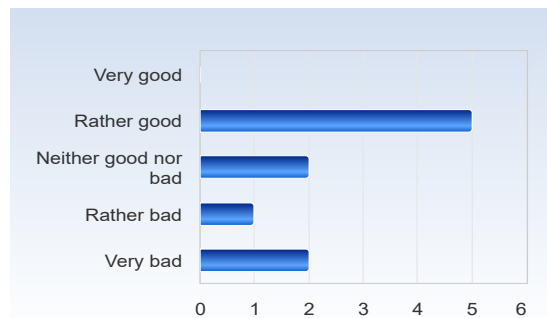
I really appreciated the flexibility of my supervisor and their willingness to help me develop the topic

The group tutorials were well-organized and effectively conducted. However, the individual supervision sessions were poorly structured and executed. The students in Fabio's group formally had 45 minutes of supervision but practically received closer to 1 hour, while those in Staffan's group formally had 30 minutes but practically received only 15-20 minutes. This lack of coordination is unfair, as it results in some students receiving significantly more supervision than others for the same assignment, which is overall unacceptable.

Overall, how would you assess the exam (course paper)?

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	Number of responses
Very good	0 (0,0%)
Rather good	5 (50,0%)
Neither good nor bad	2 (20,0%)
Rather bad	1 (10,0%)
Very bad	2 (20,0%)
Total	10 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the exam (course paper)?	3,0	1,2	41,6 %	1,0	2,5	3,5	4,0	4,0

Comment

It's unreasonable to demand that students conduct a study based on a course that is so poorly structured. Previous courses have only required research proposals. More short papers and a shorter final paper would be better in my opinion. As it stands now, I have no idea what I've learned in this course and have had to guess what to focus on in my course paper.

Not compliant with qualitative methods, I felt as so supervisors could not give feedback on qualitative approaches. Interesting, but an extra supervision, could be beneficial for our paper.

The format: really good. It is always nice to apply knowledge from the course in a final paper like this and combine it with methodological choices. But a bit more instructions would be good for the understanding of the assignment and what is expected of us.

I think the course paper is a good benchmark for assessing how we understand the theories and concepts we learned in the course

It was the only examination that effectively gave some space (and time) for the student to analyze a problem in depth.

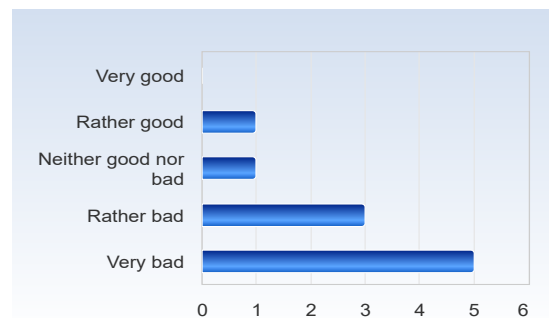
It was rewarding to work on a larger paper that mirrors the format of a thesis. This experience taught me valuable lessons in conducting research, which will benefit me when writing the actual thesis. The time given was suitable.

However, I had Staffan as a supervisor, he was not supportive, not motivating, and was predominantly derogatory and belittled me. This served as a demotivating factor for both my personal development and my educational progress.

How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (information, schedule, administration)?

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	Number of responses
Very good	0 (0,0%)
Rather good	1 (10,0%)
Neither good nor bad	1 (10,0%)
Rather bad	3 (30,0%)
Very bad	5 (50,0%)
Total	10 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (information, schedule, administration)?	1,8	1,0	57,4 %	1,0	1,0	1,5	2,0	4,0



Comment

First of all, why isn't the course reading list one single document? I've never seen it be done like this before. Second, the assignment instructions could be a bit more elaborate.

Lack of information regarding examinations and seminars. Schedules and planning changed during the course which was confusing.

We had a lack of clarity, about the grading of the exam and the activities after the seminar.

This is the where the course could improve a lot. As of this spring, the organization of the course is what almost makes me assess the course as "neither good nor bad".

1. It took too long before we knew what was needed to get high pass for the course (high pass for all assignments or not).

2. The credits for the different assignments still seem incorrect in Ladok.

3. The instructions for the short paper differed depending on which teacher you spoke to.

4. If I remember it correctly, the course guide says that we should have read each other's short papers before the seminar. However, they were not provided.

Not as clear as other courses I've had but was able to find the information eventually. Information about assignments - with the exception of the course paper - overall was unclear. I did really like the guest lecture

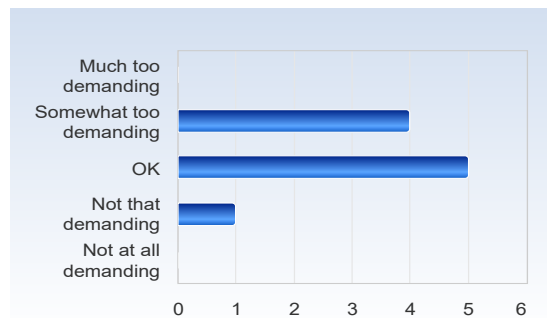
The course showed poor organization and communication abilities, especially as far as the short paper and the multiple choice exam are concerned.

All exams and one of the seminars lacked basic instructions, leading to unnecessary complexity and confusion. During one seminar, a group presentation was required, but this requirement was not communicated beforehand. For the multiple-choice exam, no instructions were provided initially. Some students contacted a teacher for clarification, and here the information received was not consistent with the actual exam format. For example, the teacher stated that there would be a question for each paper (approximately 25/30 questions), but the exam consisted of only 10 questions. The lack of organization and the absence of basic instructions for the exams are unnecessarily confusing.

The grades are still not on Ladok. This is rather frustrating considering how straightforward it is for teachers /administration to do. However, it's crucial for us students, particularly international students who rely on updated grades for the CSN offices in their home countries, visa applications, and documenting their time abroad. It's also essential for all of us when applying for internships. This issue has also occurred in previous courses.

What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:

What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:	Number of responses
Much too demanding	0 (0,0%)
Somewhat too demanding	4 (40,0%)
OK	5 (50,0%)
Not that demanding	1 (10,0%)
Not at all demanding	0 (0,0%)
Total	10 (100,0%)





	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:	3,3	0,7	20,5 %	2,0	3,0	3,0	4,0	4,0

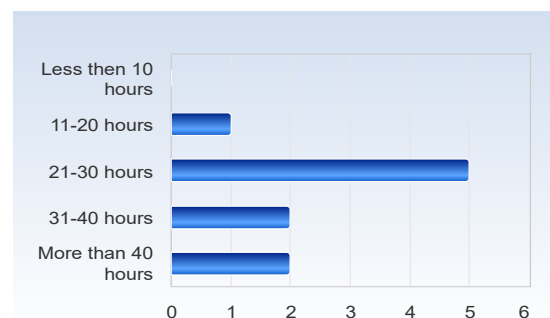
Comment

The multiple choice question covered a vast range of papers literature works. Although an overview of key topics is needed, the large amount of papers forced the student to fast-read all of them, without really providing a chance for the student to establish a serious dialogue with the literature.

On average, approximately how much time do you spend on coursework, both in and outside of the classroom, per week?

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	Number of responses
Less than 10 hours	0 (0,0%)
11-20 hours	1 (10,0%)
21-30 hours	5 (50,0%)
31-40 hours	2 (20,0%)
More than 40 hours	2 (20,0%)
Total	10 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
On average, approximately how much time do you spend on coursework, both in and outside of the classroom, per week?	3,7	1,3	36,1 %	2,0	3,0	3,0	4,0	6,0



Would you say that you had an “eureka moment” during the course, i.e. a time when you suddenly realized something that you previously did not understand or was aware of? If so, please make a short comment about it below.

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No

The way to make a qualitative analysis in social sciences.

I would say that many articles and discussions helped me understand the methodological issues and advantages in the connection to different democracy topics.

Do you have any additional points of view you would like to express?

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I would like to express my opinion regarding that the course did not feel adaptable to students who had taken a previous qualitative methods course. It clearly felt like quantitative methods was preferred especially for the final course paper. Either it should be a criteria that taking a quantitative methods course is needed or at least it should be expressed that this might be preferred. I did not feel that the supervisors could support or advice on qualitative methods.

Could be beneficial for the course program to also talk about the implications of gender inequality, specially the work made by the Digital Society Project.

I have spoken to several of my classmates and most of us, if not all of us, agree that this course has potential to be really good if the organization of information gets better.

I would suggest the staff to increase communication with the students especially when deadlines are approaching and to diminish the workload before the multiple choice exam or try other forms of examination - e.g., open questions exams - that can really test a student's ability to analyze the literature and develop critical thinking.

Very pro v-dem (and maybe a little too much), would be suitable to have a more nuanced standpoint



Finally, we want to ask for your help in our work to promote equality. The Department of Political Science works actively to prevent discrimination. Central to this is that we gain knowledge about whether, and if so, how, there are risks of harassment and discrimination, so that we can take preventive measures. If you think back on your time as a student with us from such a perspective, have you experienced contexts or situations where you think there is a certain risk for harassment and discrimination? If so, please describe these contexts or situations.

You may read more about equality treatment at GU here: [Discrimination and harassment | Student Portal \(gu.se\)](#)

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I haven't experienced any type of situation.

As I mentioned previously, one lecturer often had a condescending and dismissive attitude towards female identifying students and responded to questions from male and female students differently. A male student who had this lecturer for supervision told me that his supervision went smoothly and received positive feedback whereas a female student told me her supervision with this lecturer left her on the verge of tears and the lecturer refused to help them develop the concept.

Numerous rumors are circulating about Staffan's past and current behavior. These rumors are distracting and detracting from our focus on V-Dem and our learning.
